

S05-07 - Beyond the Contract

Player text

An hour later, back in the treehouse, the Keystone hangs suspended over a rumbling hearth-fire. The Custodian, older now, exhaustion plain in her voice, folds herself into an over-stuffed chair. "You fought hard. I'm not surprised. Emeris doesn't send just anyone." She lets you sit with it, the warmth and the weight both. And then, because there is always one more thing: she has a question about what you will tell the people who sent you, and a map to somewhere the light is going wrong.

Public objective

Wrap your story, decide how you report what happened, and learn what comes next.

Raw source

- Id: S05-07
- Type: scene
- Sectionid: ACT-FIVE
- Sectiontitle: Act Five: The Ward Renewal
- Title: Beyond the Contract
- Shorttitle: Report Choice
- Order: 607
- Playersafe: True
- Completioneligible: True
- Image: assets/scenes/S05-07-the-ward-locks-into-place.png
- Alt: The Ward Locks Into Place scene art for The Ward Renewal.
- Caption: The adventure ends with what truth the party chooses to carry forward.
- Mood: The Ward Renewal
- Gmgoal: Honor the finale, run the report choice, and bridge to the Epilogue through report_choice.
- Publicobjective: Wrap your story, decide how you report what happened, and learn what comes next.
- Readaloud: An hour later, back in the treehouse, the Keystone hangs suspended over a rumbling hearth-fire. The Custodian, older now, exhaustion plain in her voice, folds herself into an over-stuffed chair. "You fought hard. I'm not surprised. Emeris doesn't send just anyone." She lets you sit with it, the warmth and the weight both. And then, because there is always one more thing: she has a question about what you will tell the people who sent you, and a map to somewhere the light is going wrong.
- Gmnotes: The report choice is the satirical gut-punch: real heroism meets paperwork and future liability.
- Gmscript: Say: "The fight is won. Now the real question: what do you put in the report? File honest, spin corporate, refuse to report, or withhold the truth. That choice decides the Epilogue tone."
- Gmreadaloud: The Keystone hangs over a rumbling hearth-fire. The Custodian looks older now. "You fought hard. I'm not surprised. Emeris doesn't send just anyone." She asks what you will tell the people who sent you.

- Gmchecklist: Name protected_whom and honor the PC or group that covered the worst moment. Name ritual_outcome and custodian_fate in the denouement tone. Gate deeper truth: only keystone_understanding=deep + custodian_trust=high gets the strongest dread hint. Offer report_choice: file-honest, spin-corporate, refuse, withhold-the-truth. Set relay_hook_accepted if the party takes the Goldspire Relay hook. Bridge S05-07 -> S06-* by report_choice.
- Gmprivate: Truth-hint ladder low: the form has boxes for cost, blame, and recoverable asset, but no box for who was protected. Truth-hint ladder medium: the Custodian flinches when lives, memories, or warmth are described as resources. Truth-hint ladder high: only if keystone_understanding=deep and custodian_trust=high, say the frightening part is not that wards need power, but that someone learned how to profit from what protection consumes. Do not fully explain soul-economy. Let players reach for the conclusion.
- Playertakeaway: You saved a city. Now decide what story you tell about it, and whether you answer the next call.
- Storytakeaway: The adventure ends not with the fight, but with who gets to own the truth of what happened.
- Mechanictakeaway: report_choice gates the Epilogue, while ritual_outcome, protected_whom, custodian_fate, and relay_hook_accepted carry the finale forward.
- Rollcards: s05-07-help-the-ward-lock-into-place S05-07 Help the ward lock into place Help the ward lock into place Knowledge Presence Knowledge Presence 12 Knowledge supports the craft; Presence steadies the people tied to it. The ward returns unstable or emotionally hollow. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The ward returns unstable or emotionally hollow. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it...
- Entityids: keystone-asset whitefire-custodian open-valetm-ritual-site hush relay-spire goldspire-territories auditors-verdict-ledger ritual-countdown route-ledger
- Entities: keystone-asset Keystone Asset? item Item / Asset assets/icons/item.png assets/item-images/keystone-asset/profile_base.png KEE-stohn ASS-et Inside the sealed crate, packed in wax-paper and reassurance, sits a heavy grey stone the size of a loaf, warm to the touch, faintly humming, with a light deep inside it that is slowly going out. Keystone Asset?, Emeris Crown Holdings: the ward-stone that keeps Emeris safe. It is failing and must be renewed at Open Vale. The Hidden Contents Do not show this image during the Prologue. Use the sealed package instead. A massive ward-stone from the capital gate, needed to renew protective infrastructure.; use Keystone Asset as a concrete table object with texture, ownership, and a reason it matters now. Give players a tangible handle on Marlowe Fairwind, Whitefire Custodian, Open Vale? Ritual Site, whether they inspect, carry, return, trade, or refuse it. A massive ward-stone from the capital gate, needed to renew protective

infrastructure. whitefire-custodian Whitefire Custodian npc NPC / Ally
assets/icons/npc.png assets/npc-images/whitefire-custodian/portrait_base.png WHITE-
fire kus-TOH-dee-un Old faerie-like custodian who maintains the ward...

- Locationids: hush open-valetm-ritual-site relay-spire goldspire-territories
- Itemids: auditors-verdict-ledger
- Clueids: glass-bright-ward-sand
- Statecontrols: ward_stability Ward Stability select fragile stable ritual_prep
Ritual Prep select unready ready keystone_understanding Keystone Understanding
select surface deep ritual_countdown Ritual Countdown number 10 8 ritual_outcome
Ritual Outcome select unresolved clean costly pyrrhic protected_whom Protected Whom
select unresolved custodian party hush shared custodian_fate Custodian Fate select
unresolved well drained dying report_choice Report Choice select unresolved file-
honest spin-corporate refuse withhold-the-truth relay_hook_accepted Relay Hook
Accepted checkbox strixwolf_disposition Strixwolf Disposition select unresolved calm
hostile killed strixwolf_outcome Strixwolf Outcome select unresolved calmed helped
avoided attacked killed strixwolf_trust Strixwolf Trust number 3
strixwolf_blood_debt Strixwolf Blood Debt checkbox bramble_outcome Bramble Outcome
select unresolved killed captured spared negotiated escaped let_cargo
bramble_truth_learned Bramble Truth Learned checkbox package_status Package Status
select held lost hush_trust Hush Trust select low neutral high custodian_route
Custodian Route select unknown safe dangerous ward_awareness Ward Awareness select
none seed aware...
- Mechanicids: countdown hope critical-success report-choice presence fear table-
spotlight
- Playerquestions: Who do you name in the report? What truth do you refuse to give the
wrong reader? Do you take the map to the next light going wrong?
- Relationshipprompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees
about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownershipprompt: Name one detail in The Ward Locks Into Place that belongs to your
character's point of view.
- Fearsponds: Spend Fear to tick the ritual countdown, expose the Custodian, activate
ward backlash, or trigger Market Correction. Tick the Ritual Countdown the wrong
direction or expose the Custodian. Trigger Market Correction, Pass-Through, Memory
Delve, or Group Attack when fiction supports it.
- Choicesconsequences: File honest. The report says what happened plainly. Set
report_choice=file-honest. Epilogue opens with accountability pressure: the company
now knows the party knows. report_choice=file-honest Reward: truth on record. Cost:
risk. player-visible Spin corporate. The report is company-friendly: job done,
complications minimized. Set report_choice=spin-corporate. Epilogue opens smoother,
but the system digests the truth and keeps moving. report_choice=spin-corporate
Reward: clean standing. Cost: complicity. player-visible Refuse to report. The party
rejects the form entirely. Set report_choice=refuse. Epilogue opens rebellious and
unstable; silence creates pressure of its own. report_choice=refuse Reward: refusal.
Cost: no clean shield. player-visible Withhold the truth. The report says enough to
close the job but buries the deepest truth from dangerous readers. Set
report_choice=withhold-the-truth. Epilogue opens with the largest fallout arc:
people are protected now, but the hidden system has room to move.
report_choice=withhold-the-truth Reward: short-term protection. Cost: biggest future

pressure. player-visible Accept the Relay hook. The party agrees the trouble is larger than...

- Lootclues: Open Vale residue Community gratitude Strong or unstable ward tag Auditor's Verdict Ledger?: A black ledger with bronze corners opens too neatly, as if the pages have already decided what the facts will be.
- Handoutids: Ward tone
- Sourcescenelug: S05-07-the-ward-locks-into-place
- Sourcefiles: dist/Act5_Upgrade_Packet/ACT5_SCENE_RESEARCH.md
dist/Act5_Upgrade_Packet/ACT5_OPEN_QUESTIONS.md
- References: Epilogue #S06-01 Relay hook #S06-02
- Storyscope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. Soul-Audit Wraiths bear audit glyphs and say, "Unauthorized soul-resonance detected. Submit for audit."
REFLAVOR GUARANTEED A defeated wraith leaves a Soulspire compliance tag or coil-credit token instead of natural remains. ADD GUARANTEED Wraiths ignore forest creatures and home only on ritual soul-magic. ADD EARNED Instinct Medium 15 A player can read the markings and name Soulspire without the GM naming it first. ADD EARNED Knowledge Medium 15 Optional flag: Legacy Skeletons carry scraps of old corporate credentials. FLAG SEED Instinct: target logic. Knowledge: read markings. ACT5 Act 5: Open Vale defense 200 2:40 to 3:20 3:20 countdown 8, skeletons, wraiths, Market Correction Lower the countdown start to 6; cap wraith reinforcements.
- Livetools: encounter S05-07 MAP-S05-03 pages/combat/s05-03.html
- Percharacterlayer: garrick-reed Garrick Reed The report Knows exactly how a corporate report works and how to lie on one. Can walk the party through what each version really means. Garrick, you've filed reports like this before. Want to walk the party through what each version really means? marlowe-fairwind Marlowe Fairwind The truth If custodian_trust is high and keystone_understanding is deep, the Custodian trusts her with the hardest dread-hint. Knowledge/Presence gated Receives the strongest truth-hint ladder without a full soul-economy exposition. Can decide whether to carry that truth into the report. Marlowe, she trusts you with the hard truth. Do you put it in the report, or protect them from it? barnacle Barnacle The angle Calculates who profits from each report version and whether honesty has a price worth paying. Can expose the deal logic of the final choice. Barnacle, every version of this report makes someone money. Want to figure out who before you decide? khari-nix Khari Nix The conscience Feels that burying the truth may protect the party but fail the next people the system hurts. Can argue for protection beyond tonight. Khari, burying this protects you but not the next ones. Want...
- Takeawayhelp: Player takeaway You saved a city. Now decide what story you tell about it, and whether you answer the next call. "Heroes do not get a clean ending here; they get a form to fill out. What do you write? And do you take the next job?" "Say goodbye to the Custodian, ask what you have been holding, choose the report, and decide whether the Relay hook stays open." Let players talk. This is the final agency beat. report-choice presence table-spotlight Story takeaway The adventure ends not with the fight, but with who gets to own the truth of what happened. "The fight is won. Now the real question is what story leaves this clearing, and who that story protects." "If they understand the cost, the report is moral pressure. If they

do not, it is still how they frame a job well done." Report choice is the story thesis; do not reduce it to bookkeeping. report-choice presence table-spotlight Mechanic takeaway report_choice gates the Epilogue, while ritual_outcome, protected_whom, custodian_fate, and relay_hook_accepted carry the finale forward. "Set report_choice now: file-honest, spin-corporate, refuse, or withhold-the-truth. Then set whether they accept the Relay hook." "file-honest risks..."

- Playerbeats: s05-07-treehouse After The treehouse after assets/scenes/S05-07-the-ward-locks-into-place.png The Ward Locks Into Place scene art for The Ward Renewal. The Keystone hangs over the hearth. The Custodian looks older, tired, and grateful. The Keystone hangs over the hearth. The Custodian looks older, tired, and grateful. The Keystone hangs over the hearth. The Custodian looks older, tired, and grateful. text-first s05-07-truth Truth What she tells you assets/scenes/S05-07-the-ward-locks-into-place.png The Ward Locks Into Place scene art for The Ward Renewal. She answers what she can, and what she cannot say still has weight. She answers what she can, and what she cannot say still has weight. She answers what she can, and what she cannot say still has weight. text-first s05-07-report Report What goes in the report assets/scenes/S05-07-the-ward-locks-into-place.png The Ward Locks Into Place scene art for The Ward Renewal. Choose the report path: file honest, spin corporate, refuse to report, or withhold the truth. Choose the report path: file honest, spin corporate, refuse to report, or withhold the truth. Choose the report path: file honest, spin corporate, refuse to report, or...
- Gmbeats: s05-07-treehouse After The treehouse after Say: "Let the warmth and exhaustion sit together. This is not a victory lap; it is a landing." The Keystone hangs over the hearth. The Custodian looks older, tired, and grateful. The fight's cost enters the room. Outcome state colors tone. Players get denouement warmth. Player takeaway Players get denouement warmth. "Let the warmth and exhaustion sit together. This is not a victory lap; it is a landing." "The table-facing answer is: Players get denouement warmth." Use this beat to give the players one visible next action: protect the center, read the field, spend prep, name who they shield, or choose what truth leaves with them. table-spotlight Story takeaway The fight's cost enters the room. "Let the warmth and exhaustion sit together. This is not a victory lap; it is a landing." "The story answer is: The fight's cost enters the room." Tie the answer to a visible Act 5 consequence: the ward steadies, the Custodian suffers, Hush is protected, or the final report changes who owns the truth. table-spotlight Mechanic takeaway Outcome state colors tone. "Let the warmth and exhaustion sit together. This is not a victory lap; it is a..."
- Beatautoplayeligible: True
- Beatautoplaydefault: False
- Beatautoplayintervalms: 9000
- Playersafeprojection: S05-07 scene Beyond the Contract assets/scenes/S05-07-the-ward-locks-into-place.png The Ward Locks Into Place scene art for The Ward Renewal. The adventure ends with what truth the party chooses to carry forward. The Ward Renewal Wrap your story, decide how you report what happened, and learn what comes next. An hour later, back in the treehouse, the Keystone hangs suspended over a rumbling hearth-fire. The Custodian, older now, exhaustion plain in her voice, folds herself into an over-stuffed chair. "You fought hard. I'm not surprised. Emeris doesn't send just anyone." She lets you sit with it, the warmth and the weight both. And then, because there is always one more thing: she has a question about what you

will tell the people who sent you, and a map to somewhere the light is going wrong.
s05-07-treehouse After The treehouse after assets/scenes/S05-07-the-ward-locks-into-
place.png The Ward Locks Into Place scene art for The Ward Renewal. The Keystone
hangs over the hearth. The Custodian looks older, tired, and grateful. The Keystone
hangs over the hearth. The Custodian looks older, tired, and grateful. The Keystone
hangs over the hearth. The Custodian looks older, tired, and...

- Companionmaps: MAP-S05-03 MAP-LOC-open-valetm-ritual-site MAP-LOC-goldspire-territories
- Slidenumber: 75
- Totalslides: 110
- Spotlights: SPOT-M-REPORT the-report-choice the-report-choice M22 S05-07 high
mandatory beat:report How Will You Report? The one-shot's values check is front-and-
center. You have four valid endings: file honest, spin corporate, refuse, or
withhold the truth. No move is right. Each move chooses a different consequence. Ask
the table what they write, what they omit, and who they protect. Report choice
wiki/mechanic/the-report-choice consequences-and-hints Consequence chain
wiki/mechanic/consequence-chain consequences-and-hints Make the final ethical choice
visible and playable. mechanic defer-if-clock-critical True True SPOT-C-GARRICK-LATE
garrick-reed Garrick Reed late S05-07 high optional beat:report Garrick, File It
Right Reporting experience turns into an ethics anchor. Garrick, you know how
filings work. Frame the party's truth and ownership now. Spotlight: Garrick
wiki/character/garrick in-scene-prompts The report choice wiki/mechanic/the-report-
choice consequences-and-hints character defer-if-clock-critical True True
- Spotlightsummary: 1 1

Export Stamp

Build 2026-07-05T12:33:16 | Content hash c859c09423f0f2a5 | Source hash
6753a06c32e5dca07a19eb73